The Fourteenth Session of the Inter-Etherian Committee for General Arbitration

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24951466.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by EmperorNorton150

Summary

It's been a little over a year since the Princess Alliance and the Horde signed their historic peace treaty. But in some ways, peace turns out to be harder to manage than war.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

She was going to see Catra today! Adora still wasn't totally sure what she thought about that. Good? Definitely good, but also kind of sad, and maybe still a little bit angry? Not to mention nervous. It had been fourteen months since Catra had dropped her series of (mostly metaphorical) bombshells on Etheria, and Adora was still trying to find her feet. She had just about accepted finally that Catra was really, truly her enemy—and now she wasn't again? I mean, it wasn't like it was before, they still weren't friends, but they could talk now. They could work together. They'd discovered that in the endless meetings that had seemingly colonized everyone's lives, as the Princess Alliance and the Horde tried to figure out a way to defend their shared homeworld from this "Horde Prime" that Entrapta had warned them about. And sometimes, after the meeting was over, and or one of the occasional "joint inspection trips" they'd taken (she *still* didn't she why they couldn't just call them "missions"), they would……just talk. It was strange. Catra wasn't the same as she'd been before everything changed. She was more self-confident now, more assertive. Calmer. Less prone to explosions of rage, but less obvious about what she was thinking. Adora still couldn't exactly forgive her for spending a solid *two years* trying to murder her and her friends but……it felt good to see her again. Glimmer was still half-convinced this was all some kind of trick, but—Adora's train of thought broke off abruptly as Catra strode into the meeting hall, the gold epaulets on her red uniform shining, her white cloak fluttering, Force General Scorpia trotting at her heels carrying a satchel of documents and whistling.

"Hi!" Adora whispered as the Generalissimo of the Horde settled into a chair across from her. Catra gave her a small smile and a little wave, and Adora felt something catch in her throat. She'd forgotten how much she missed having Catra around. Maybe after today's session they could, like, hang out or something. (*Were Heads of State allowed to hang out? She wasn't sure*). Whatever. They could at least talk about politics or government or lunar defensive batteries or whatever Important Stuff Catra was thinking about today—a soft chime ran through the room, as Chairman Bow took his seat and tapped the crystal

bell with his gavel. There was a scuffling as everyone turned their attention to the head of the table, and Adora grabbed her notebook and tried to put Catra out of her mind.

First, she had to get through today's meeting.

"Ladies and gentlemen, thank you all for your attendance here today" proclaimed Bow, smiling out at the assembled leaders of Etheria, "and welcome to the Fourteenth Session of the Inter-Etherian Committee for General Arbitration. Together, we can work together to ensure that our planet remains at peace and that we all remain on the friendliest of relations. I like to think that's a goal we can *all* agree on". The Chairman looked down at his pad, and his smile thinned a little. "The first item on the agenda is—" he sighed, and took a deep breath. "The Kingdom of Salineas has lodged a complaint with this Committee that Horde fishing vessels are trespassing in Salinean waters. Again". Catra leaned back in her chair and languidly raised a hand.

"Mr. Chairman, I object to this *very hurtful* allegation. I have investigated the matter, and have ensured that all of the Horde ships remained within ten leagues of Iron Fist island. Salineas has no jurisdiction within our sovereign waters, no matter their pretensions". *BAM!* Mermista's fist slammed onto the table.

"That island is an integral part of the Kingdom of Salineas you furry little liar!" she shouted. Catra adopted a look of exaggerated surprise, mingled with sadness.

"That is absurd, and I wish I knew why Princess Mermista was advancing these revanchist territorial claims on Iron Fist—"

"UGH, would you *stop* calling it that?"

"Oh? What should I call it then Your Highness? Mermista rolled her eyes.

"It's called Whale Tail island, *obviously*. If you don't even know that, how can you, like, claim to own it?" Catra

snapped her fingers.

"Scorpia, would you please tell me how the island in question is identified in the Horde First General Planetary Survey?"

"Oooh! Oooh! I love this game! Let's see, I know I have it here somewhere, gosh, just gimme a second." Everyone waited as Catra's adjutant fished around in her satchel before finally emerging with a impressive-looking document, marked with a red seal. "A-ha! Here it is! And, well, whadaya know, it says 'Iron Fist Island'!" She beamed. "Not what I would've guessed at all!" Mermista's hands clenched on the edge of the table.

"I don't, like, recognize your stupid First whatever Planetary Survey as a legitimate authority!"

"Well, that's hardly my problem, is it?"

"It is when you're *trespassing* on my island!" Bow broke in before Catra could respond.

"Your Excellency, perhaps you could inform us as to the basis of your claims?" The leader of the Horde graced the Chairman with a smile.

"Of course, Mr. Chairman. I would be happy to. Scorpia, hand me the Map please?"

"Aye-aye boss!" She handed Catra a weathered, browning scroll, which Catra unfurled onto the conference table with a great fanfare, revealing a map of the Etherian Ocean. She gestured grandly at the chart.

"As you can see here, this *ancient* and very *historic* map *clearly* indicates that the territorial division between the Kingdom of Salineas and the Horde lies a full twenty leagues west of *Iron Fist Island*. The evidence is indisputable." There was a moment of silence as everyone squinted at the map. Bow finally spoke up.

"Catra……I think that's a smudge". She frowned.

"No, no, I'm pretty sure it's a line of demarcation. Otherwise, why would it be on the map?"

"Seriously, I think it's some dirt."

"No, it's a line. See, there's nine little marks, starting from the southern coast and then going up past Skelton Atoll."

"I think you mean *Pearl Reef* loser" muttered Mermista. Bow shot a glare at her, while Catra continued her spiel.

"Let's see, one, two, ummm, that's the third one, four, five, hmmm ok, *that* one might be a speck of dirt, fine, uh, six, uhhh, seven, eight, and……..nine". She tapped a spot of ocean decisively. "A nine-dash line, just as I said!" Catra laced her hands together over her head and stretched, smirking. Bow pinched the bridge of his nose and sighed deeply. Queen Angella had been the first Chairwoman of the Inter-Etherian Committee for General Arbitration. She had lasted two sessions before delegating it to Glimmer, who had attempted to murder Catra *and* Mermista in her first session, at which point Princess Perfuma had volunteered to take over the gavel and lasted a full session and-a-half before breaking down in tears, at which Bow had been conscripted into the job. Unfortunately for him, he'd turned out to be good at it.

"Thank you for presenting your……evidence, Your Excellency. Princess Mermista, would you like to respond?"

"Duh! She's just, like, making everything up, as usual".

"Would you please inform the Committee as to the evidence supporting *your* claim, Your Highness?" Mermista rolled her eyes again and began to recite in a singsong voice.

"In the beginning there was the Wave and the Water and the Sand and all the creatures of the ocean swam about in confusion for there was no one to order them or guide them. Then my Grandmother's Grandmother came from the North on a

cloud of rain and wind and she placed her trident in the sand of the beach and said that it was good and erected there a city where she would hold her court and all the people saw her and made obeisance to her for they saw that she held the power of the stone within her. They named her Princess of Salineas and she accepted their allegiance and promised to protect them from all things evil for all time. Then my Grandmother's Grandmother swam out to sea she sang to the land and the sea and the foam and they sang back and she taught the Song of the Sea to her daughter who taught it to her daughter who taught it her daughter who taught it to her daughter who taught it to me and the song tells us all that we must protect and nurture and *it explicitly includes Whale Tale Island you stupid cat!*"

"Point of order Mr. Chairman! I refuse to accept baseless superstitions as evidence pertaining to matters of international law!"

"It is *not* baseless superstition it is my *heritage* and I'll —" Both girls started shouting and the argument turned into an incomprehensible cacophony, with onlookers only able to catch the occasional phrase.

"Crush your pathetic kingdom into dust—"

"Uh, really now? I don't remember the Horde ever breaking through the Gate of Salineas before soooo—"

"Hordak was an old fool and a coward, I'll show you what the Horde is capable of with a real leader—"

"Whatever cat lady, I'm real scared—"

"I could have an amphibious assault group storming your precious little gate by this time tomorrow—"

With a great deal of vigorous chiming and a far amount of shouting, Bow finally managed to gain control of the meeting. He glared at the two leaders, who were in turn glaring at each other.

"Ok then! Let's try a different approach, shall we? Does anyone live on Iron—I mean, Whal—*on the island in question?*"

"No" muttered Mermista.

"Yes!" crowed Catra, slapping the table gleefully.

"*Is that person a Horde soldier who you sent to the island before this meeting specifically for the purpose of claiming it?*"

"……maybe".

"That's what I thought. So. Why does *any* of this matter to you people?" After a minute Mermista finally grumbled

"She's like, overfishing the area, ok? That's a valuable natural resource and she's stealing it all."

"My people need food too princess!" snapped Catra.

"Don't you guys just like, eat ration bars?"

"Where do you think ration bars *come* from you numbskull? They don't grow on trees!"

"*Ok then!*" interjected Bow forcefully. "If I might suggest a compromise?" Both girls glared at him, but nodded. Bow continued. "Let us agree to table the actual question of sovereignty over, uhh, the island for now and" he sighed deeply "take it up again next session. For now, both the Horde and Salineas will agree to send only two fishing vessels per month into the disputed waters." Both girls opened their mouths but Bow drove over the objections. "*Bright Moon will send neutral observers to monitor the situation!* Is this……acceptable?"

"Fine, whatever, I guess" Mermista sneered. "It's still my island though".

"The Etherian Horde finds this to be an acceptable compromise……for now" purred Catra, her fur bristling. Bow smiled.

"Splendid! Now let's continue". He tapped his pad, making a note of the agreement. Then his face fell. He sighed and took a deep breath. "Next on the agenda……. the Kingdom of Bright Moon has lodged a complaint with this Committee that the Horde is illegally harvesting lumber from the Whispering Woods. Again".

"Mr. Chairman, I object to this *outrageous* allegation. I have investigated this matter, and have ensured that all of our harvesting occurred in the part of the forest on the northern bank of Bloody River, so I cannot understand the complaint—" *BAM!* Glimmer's fist slammed onto the table.

"Those woods are an integral part of the Kingdom of Bright Moon horde scum!" she shouted. Catra frowned sadly.

"Yes, yes, to be sure, but under the Treaty of Elberon the Horde has the right to gather resources as far south as the river—"

"The Treaty of *what*?" shrieked Glimmer. "I've never even heard of that!" Catra shrugged.

"It was signed four hundred and twelve years ago, between the Kingdom of Bright Moon and King Scorpios IV of the Kingdom of Scorpions. As suzerain protector of said Kingdom, its terms apply to the Horde as well, and are fully enforceable. Thus, my people have the right to cut lumber north of the Blood River. It's not *that* complicated sparkles."

"That's ridiculous! Bow, tell her that's stupid". Bow, with a look of mounting confusion and misery on his face, didn't answer, as he was frantically flipping through several books of Etherian precedent law. Catra chucked, and Glimmer glowered at

her again. "And *stop* calling it the Bloody River! Everyone knows it's the Ruby River!" Catra snapped her fingers.

"Scorpia, would you please tell me how this particular river is identified in the Horde First General Planetary Survey?"

"Ooh! Let's find out, gosh, I wonder what it could be, just give me one minute here, ooh! Well, I'll be! It says—"

Adora closed her eyes and nestled her head on her crossed arms on the table. Things were going well. At least it wasn't as bad as *last* month.

End Notes

- The She-Ra and the Princesses of Power/South China Sea Maritime Border Dispute crossover fanfic you all were waiting for

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!